

Snake



POEM TEXT

1 A snake came to my water-trough
 2 On a hot, hot day, and I in pyjamas for the heat,
 3 To drink there.

 4 In the deep, strange-scented shade of the great dark
 carob tree
 5 I came down the steps with my pitcher
 6 And must wait, must stand and wait, for there he was at
 the trough before me.

 7 He reached down from a fissure in the earth-wall in the
 gloom
 8 And trailed his yellow-brown slackness soft-bellied
 down, over the edge of the stone trough
 9 And rested his throat upon the stone bottom,
 10 And where the water had dripped from the tap, in a
 small clearness,
 11 He sipped with his straight mouth,
 12 Softly drank through his straight gums, into his slack
 long body,
 13 Silently.

 14 Someone was before me at my water-trough,
 15 And I, like a second-comer, waiting.

 16 He lifted his head from his drinking, as cattle do,
 17 And looked at me vaguely, as drinking cattle do,
 18 And flickered his two-forked tongue from his lips, and
 mused a moment,
 19 And stooped and drank a little more,
 20 Being earth-brown, earth-golden from the burning
 bowels of the earth
 21 On the day of Sicilian July, with Etna smoking.

 22 The voice of my education said to me
 23 He must be killed,
 24 For in Sicily the black, black snakes are innocent, the
 gold are venomous.

 25 And voices in me said, If you were a man
 26 You would take a stick and break him now, and finish
 him off.

27 But must I confess how I liked him,
 28 How glad I was he had come like a guest in quiet, to
 drink at my water-trough
 29 And depart peaceful, pacified, and thankless,
 30 Into the burning bowels of this earth?

 31 Was it cowardice, that I dared not kill him?
 32 Was it perversity, that I longed to talk to him?
 33 Was it humility, to feel so honoured?
 34 I felt so honoured.

 35 And yet those voices:
 36 If you were not afraid, you would kill him.

 37 And truly I was afraid, I was most afraid,
 38 But even so, honoured still more
 39 That he should seek my hospitality
 40 From out the dark door of the secret earth.

 41 He drank enough
 42 And lifted his head, dreamily, as one who has drunken,
 43 And flickered his tongue like a forked night on the air,
 so black,
 44 Seeming to lick his lips,
 45 And looked around like a god, unseeing, into the air,
 46 And slowly turned his head,
 47 And slowly, very slowly, as if thrice adream,
 48 Proceeded to draw his slow length curving round
 49 And climb again the broken bank of my wall-face.

 50 And as he put his head into that dreadful hole,
 51 And as he slowly drew up, snake-easing his shoulders,
 and entered farther,
 52 A sort of horror, a sort of protest against his
 withdrawing into that horrid black hole,
 53 Deliberately going into the blackness, and slowly
 drawing himself after,
 54 Overcame me now his back was turned.

 55 I looked round, I put down my pitcher,
 56 I picked up a clumsy log
 57 And threw it at the water-trough with a clatter.

 58 I think it did not hit him,
 59 But suddenly that part of him that was left behind

convulsed in an undignified haste,
60 Writhed like lightning, and was gone
61 Into the black hole, the earth-lipped fissure in the wall-
front,
62 At which, in the intense still noon, I stared with
fascination.

63 And immediately I regretted it.
64 I thought how paltry, how vulgar, what a mean act!
65 I despised myself and the voices of my accursed human
education.

66 And I thought of the albatross,
67 And I wished he would come back, my snake.

68 For he seemed to me again like a king,
69 Like a king in exile, uncrowned in the underworld,
70 Now due to be crowned again.

71 And so, I missed my chance with one of the lords
72 Of life.
73 And I have something to expiate:
74 A pettiness.



SUMMARY

A snake came to drink at the water trough in my yard, on a day so hot that I was wearing pajamas to stay cool.

In the dark, funny-smelling shade of the huge, dark carob tree, I walked down my steps, carrying a water pitcher, and had to stand around waiting at the trough, because the snake had gotten there first.

The snake slithered down in the shade from a crack in the mud wall; slid his soft, loose, yellow-brown body over the rim of the stone trough; and flattened his head against the stone bottom. He drank from the little pool of clear water around the tap, sipping through his gums into his horizontal slit of a mouth, noiselessly taking the water into his long, loose body.

He had beaten me to the trough, and I had to wait, like a latecomer.

He raised his head from the water, the way cows do, and gave me a distracted look, the way cows do while drinking. He shot his forked tongue out, thought for a second, bent down, and drank some more water. He was brown as soil, having come from the hellish depths of the earth on this July day in Sicily, as smoke rose from Mount Etna.

The rational voice inside me said, *You have to kill him*, because in Sicily, it's the black snakes that are harmless and the yellow-

brown snakes that are poisonous.

Voices in my head taunted me: *If you were a real man, you'd grab a stick and kill him right now.*

But do I have to admit how much I liked the snake? How happy I was that he'd arrived quietly, like a houseguest, to sip from my trough—and go peacefully, satisfied, without thanking me, back down into the hellish underground?

Was I a coward for not wanting to kill him? Was I an eccentric for wanting to speak with him instead? Was I humble because I felt honored by his presence? (I did indeed feel very honored.)

Still, the voices inside me said: *If you weren't scared, you'd kill him.*

And I really was scared, very scared—but more than that, honored that he'd come from the dark, hidden underground to seek me out as his host.

He finished drinking and raised his head, dazed, as if he'd been drinking liquor; darted his forked tongue, which was black as night; and seemed to lick his chops. He gazed at the air around, aloof as a god; turned his head around slowly, as if asleep three times over; then curved his body around and slithered back up the cracked earthen wall.

And as he slid into his awful hole—slowly reared up, as if shrugging, and poked his head down farther—a kind of disgust, a revulsion against his disappearing into that terrible pit, purposely descending into that darkness and taking his long body with him, filled me now that he was turned in the other direction.

I glanced around, set down my water pitcher, grabbed a bulky log, and hurled it toward the trough, where it landed with a crash.

I'm pretty sure it missed the snake, but now the part of him still above ground trembled, awkwardly hurrying; whipped around in a flash; and vanished into the dark hole, the dirt-rimmed crack in the wall. I gazed at the hole, mesmerized, in the silent, blazing noon heat.

Right away, I wished I hadn't thrown the log. I scolded myself: how petty, how lowly, what a shabby thing to do! I hated myself and the educated, rational voices inside me.

I thought of the albatross from the poem "The Rime of the Ancient Mariner"—which hangs like a curse around the sailor who kills it—and I wished my snake would return to my yard.

Because now I thought of him again as royalty: an exiled king from the underworld, gone back to reclaim his crown.

That's how I botched my encounter with one of the kings of Nature. And now I have to atone for my small-minded meanness.



THEMES



FEAR, AWE, AND MALE INSECURITY

The speaker of D. H. Lawrence's "Snake" tells a psychologically complex anecdote about encountering a snake in his yard. Approaching his "water-trough" to refill a pitcher on a hot day in Sicily, he finds a yellowish, poisonous snake that has come to drink there before him. Cycling through various emotions, the speaker is "afraid" of and awed by the snake but also oddly resentful of this impressive "lord[] of life." After he clumsily hurls a log at the snake—which isn't trying to harm him at all—he's overcome with self-loathing at the "pettiness" of his "mean act." What awes and impresses us, the poem suggests, can also make us feel resentful and threatened, causing us to lash out in foolish ways. And this may be especially true for men, whose sense of *masculinity* is easily threatened by perceived competition.

Encountering the snake, the speaker feels a mix of fear and wonder, as well as a strange affinity toward the creature. He admits that's he's "most afraid" of the snake and believes, on an intellectual level, that it "must be killed" because it's poisonous. His fear of the snake also involves an irrational dread of the unknown, [symbolized](#) by the "horrid black hole" from which the snake comes and to which it returns. (This hole might also be symbolically related to sex, birth, death, or all three.) Despite his fear, the speaker also "like[s]" the snake and compares it to a "guest" of honor. In its "gold" armor, the snake reminds the speaker of a "king in exile." It even seems to have a divine quality: it "look[s] around like a god" who's emerged "from the burning bowels of the earth." On some level, then, the speaker feels quite "honoured" that the snake has paid him a visit.

At the same time, the encounter plays on the speaker's insecurities, prompting him to try to dominate or kill the snake. Impressed as he is, he chides himself, "If you were not afraid, you would kill him." Overcoming his ambivalence, the speaker chucks a "log" at the snake—and, apparently, misses. It's probably no coincidence that both log and snake have a phallic shape: the speaker seems to be trying to assert a kind of masculine as well as human dominance. His inner "voices" jeer that "If [he] were a man," he'd be able to get the job done (a hint that the poem, in a coded and symbolic way, is partly about sexual potency and impotence).

When the speaker's petty power move accomplishes nothing (the snake gets away), he's left feeling even more insecure and ashamed than before. He acknowledges that he "immediately [...] regretted" throwing the log and scolds himself for his "mean," "vulgar" show of force. He implies that he should have simply marveled at the snake's glory rather than spitefully trying to destroy it. In other words, he should have trusted his awe, not his fear and "paltry" resentment.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-74



DIGNITY, INDIGNITY, AND DISHONOR

"Snake" contrasts the lordly dignity of a snake with the indignity, awkwardness, and dishonor of the human speaker. After trying to kill the snake, a beautiful creature that wasn't harming him, the speaker feels he's made a fool of himself and earned a kind of shame. Indeed, he seems to feel he's both a bad host to his regal "guest" and an inferior creature in general. As an insecure human being, he has blundered in the presence of this natural "god" or "king." By confessing his shame to the reader, the speaker strives to atone for his dishonor—perhaps implying that art and truth-telling can redeem lower forms of human behavior.

The speaker presents the snake as a graceful, even regal creature, setting up a contrast with his own clumsy and ignoble behavior. Many stories (e.g., the Eden myth) and [idioms](#) (e.g., "snake in the grass") portray snakes as low, undignified, or evil creatures, since they crawl on the earth and can kill humans. Yet the speaker imagines this poisonous snake as a regal presence gracing his property: "Was it humility, to feel so honoured? / I felt so honoured." As a "guest," the snake is on his best behavior: "quiet," "peaceful," and self-reliant (he helps himself to the speaker's water, then departs). The speaker feels flattered that the snake "should seek my hospitality / From out the dark door of the secret earth." Yet he betrays his responsibilities as a host, chasing his "guest" away for no good reason. Meanwhile, the snake's regal demeanor wavers for one moment only. When the speaker throws the log, the part of the snake still above ground "convulse[s] / in an undignified haste."

In making the snake look undignified for one moment, however, the speaker sacrifices all his own dignity. In a way, he's thrown the log to avoid dishonor—to please the internal "voices" that tell him, "If you were a man / You would [...] finish him off." But afterward he feels only shame. He chides himself: "[H]ow paltry, how vulgar, what a mean act!" He seems to feel his behavior is unworthy of the snake, which is so coolly self-possessed and unconcerned with others. His shame reads as an [ironic](#) twist on the Eden story: unlike Adam and Eve, the speaker disgraces himself by *rejecting* a serpent, not heeding one.

In the end, then, the poem is a kind of unburdening—the speaker's belated attempt to recover some dignity through truth-telling or storytelling. He concludes that "I have something to expiate: / A pettiness." The word "expiate" has religious [connotations](#): it means to atone for some sin or offense. The poem itself, then, can be read as an attempt at expiation, or a confession of guilt and shame. The speaker seems to hope that he can transform his "pett[y]" behavior into

something redemptive: an honest piece of writing.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 25-26
- Lines 27-30
- Lines 31-34
- Lines 35-36
- Lines 37-40
- Lines 41-49
- Lines 55-74



HUMAN CIVILIZATION VS. NATURE

Like many poems featuring both humans and animals, "Snake" stages a conflict between human civilization and nature. The gold snake, a [symbol](#) of nature's beauty and potential danger, behaves as a kind of peaceful neighbor or houseguest. Meanwhile, the speaker *feels* instinctive respect for the snake—but since he *knows* the snake is poisonous, his "accursed human education" gets the better of him. Acting on his supposedly rational knowledge, he tries to kill the snake rather than letting it be. Broadly, the poem suggests that, instead of coexisting respectfully with nature, humans often turn encounters with wild creatures into needless power struggles. Our civilized education can therefore become a kind of curse, as it hinders a more organic, intuitive, and healthy relationship with the world around us.

The speaker turns what could have been a moment of connection with nature into a moment of conflict. Though he knows the snake could theoretically kill him, he's at first inclined to treat the snake as an honored "guest." He recognizes that the snake is not only beautiful but "peaceful" as it goes about its business; in fact, it behaves as tamely as domestic "cattle." Despite his instinctive respect, the speaker listens to "The voice of my education," which says the snake "must be killed." In other words, he respects the snake, but not quite enough. Halfheartedly, he tries to kill the creature, spoiling what had been an awe-inspiring encounter.

The speaker essentially blames his blunder on human civilization, which treats nature as a stranger or enemy rather than a part of our world. Filled with regret after his weak attempt at snake-killing, the speaker "despise[s] myself and the voices of my accursed human education." This education, he implies, stems from a larger and generally toxic human culture: one that seeks total dominance over nature, and can't tolerate anything that might harm or frustrate humans. Indeed, the speaker's education overrides his first, healthier impulse: to behave "hospita[bly]" toward the snake (or nature in general).

The poem intimates that if this kind of "human education" is a curse, a more respectful relationship to nature would be a blessing. (Much of D. H. Lawrence's writing criticizes what he perceived as the soullessness of modern, mechanized

civilization, and urges a return to more intuitive or "primitive" ways of living.)

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-74



MISSED OPPORTUNITIES AND REGRET

After throwing a log at the snake, the speaker of "Snake" feels not only foolish but disappointed: he feels he's "missed [his] chance with one of the lords / Of life." Though he doesn't specify what kind of "chance" he believes he's missed, it seems to involve a deeper bond with or appreciation of this impressive creature. He even feels he may have incurred some sort of curse or bad luck. The poem thus seems to warn against taking nature's beauty and power for granted. More generally, perhaps, it warns against focusing solely on the downside of ambiguous or challenging situations—treating them as pure crises rather than potential opportunities.

Though most of the poem is emotionally conflicted, it ends with clear and bitter regret. In other words, the speaker's anecdote turns into a warning story. The speaker sighs: "I wished he would come back, my snake." Reviewing the encounter with a clear mind, he feels wistful affection ("my snake") rather than fear. The speaker even "th[inks] of the albatross"—that is, the bird from Samuel Taylor Coleridge's famous poem "[The Rime of the Ancient Mariner](#)," which becomes a symbol of bad luck and regret after the mariner kills it. In other words, although the snake has escaped unharmed, the speaker feels deep regret and dread, as if attacking it might have brought bad luck or offended the gods.

The speaker specifically warns against "pettiness," but more broadly, he's warning against failures of courage and imagination. It's implied that these qualities would have helped him seize the moment during his encounter with the snake. They would have helped him appreciate the snake as peaceful rather than threatening, beautiful rather than dreadful, and so on. Even if he isn't literally cursed, then, he's left with lasting disappointment. Without stating its lesson outright, the poem encourages readers to make more of their own "chance[s]"—to treat moments of ambivalence and vulnerability as opportunities for learning and growth.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 63-74



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-6

*A snake came to my water-trough
On a hot, hot day, and I in pyjamas for the heat,
To drink there.
In the deep, strange-scented shade of the great dark carob
tree
I came down the steps with my pitcher
And must wait, must stand and wait, for there he was at the
trough before me.*

Lines 1-6 set the scene for the poem's extended anecdote. The speaker, a first-person narrator, recalls encountering one of nature's most unnerving animals: "A snake."

The [setting](#) seems to be a yard of some kind at the speaker's residence, baking under the sun "On a hot, hot day." The midday "heat" is so fierce that the speaker is still wearing light "pyjamas" in an effort to stay cool. He's carrying a "pitcher" to a "water-trough" (a sort of water fountain) in the yard, presumably in order to fill it at the tap and get a cool drink. But as he walks "down the steps" toward the trough, he finds that the thirsty snake has gotten there first. Instead of getting instant relief from the heat, then, he "must wait, must stand and wait." (Notice how the [repetition](#) here slows down the line and helps convey the speaker's impatience.)

This little encounter takes place "In the deep, strange-scented shade of [a] great dark carob tree," where the water-trough is located. The carob is an evergreen shrub or tree native to the Middle East and Mediterranean regions (this poem takes place, as line 21 reveals, on the Mediterranean island of Sicily). It has a broad crown, fruit pods, and an unusual odor that's often described as sexual—in fact, often compared to semen.

Right away, then, through a mix of visual and olfactory (smell-based) [imagery](#), the poem hints that it might be exploring some "deep," "dark," potentially sex-related regions of the human psyche. It might be exploring masculinity in particular (notice, too, that the snake is a common phallic [symbol](#)). In fact, while "Snake" goes on to relate a fairly long story—in sprawling, chatty [free verse](#)—very little actually *happens* in the poem. Instead, the main action is psychological: it's all about what's going on beneath the surface, inside the speaker's mind.

LINES 7-13

*He reached down from a fissure in the earth-wall in the
gloom
And trailed his yellow-brown slackness soft-bellied down,
over the edge of the stone trough
And rested his throat upon the stone bottom,
And where the water had dripped from the tap, in a small
clearness,
He sipped with his straight mouth,*

*Softly drank through his straight gums, into his slack long
body,
Silently.*

In lines 7-13, the speaker begins to observe the snake closely, in intricate, novelistic detail. (D. H. Lawrence was more famous for his fiction than his poetry, and his training as a novelist clearly informs the poem's long, prose-like, descriptive passages.)

The speaker watches the snake as its long body "reache[s] down from a fissure"—a crack or hole—"in the earth-wall." This seems to be the wall that the trough is built into, and it's made of "earth" or dried mud. "In the gloom" beneath the carob tree, the snake "trails" the "slackness" (looseness) of its "yellow brown [...] soft-bellied" body "over the edge of the stone trough."

Notice two things here: first, the speaker describes the snake as male ("He"), even though he probably doesn't know its sex for sure. Second, he uses long lines and precise, layered verbs and adjectives to capture every detail of the snake's movement. It's as if he's following the snake's path inch by inch. Already, this effect tips off the reader that the speaker is afraid (as he will later confess). He perceives a potential threat and is keeping a close eye on it. Moreover, he perceives it as a *masculine* threat—perhaps a threat to his own masculinity.

Once in the trough, the snake "rests his throat upon the stone bottom" and begins to drink. These lines are loaded with hissing, [sibilant](#) sounds, which seem especially appropriate to a passage about a snake:

*And where the water had dripped from the tap, in a
small clearness,
He sipped with his straight mouth,
Softly drank through his straight gums, into his slack
long body,
Silently.*

Details such as the "straight gums" seem based on close observation of real-life snakes. But as precise and naturalistic as the visual [imagery](#) is here, there's a notable lack of sound imagery to accompany it. The snake drinks "Softly" and "Silently" as the speaker freezes and waits. The silence heightens the tension of the scene, hinting at the speaker's fear long before he acknowledges it in line 37.

LINES 14-21

*Someone was before me at my water-trough,
And I, like a second-comer, waiting.
He lifted his head from his drinking, as cattle do,
And looked at me vaguely, as drinking cattle do,
And flickered his two-forked tongue from his lips, and mused
a moment,
And stooped and drank a little more,*

Being earth-brown, earth-golden from the burning bowels of the earth

On the day of Sicilian July, with Etna smoking.

Lines 14-21 cover two [stanzas](#), the first of which has only two lines. This [couplet](#) marks a kind of interlude between the long descriptive stanzas before and after. It's not strictly necessary to the poem's [narrative](#); the speaker simply repeats that the snake ([anthropomorphized](#) as "Someone," not "Something") has come "before [him] to the water trough." The animal has slipped in ahead of the human being, leaving the speaker "like a second-comer, waiting."

Notice that the speaker sounds miffed here, as if he's in *competition* with the snake. It seems to wound his human—or masculine—pride that he has to stand "waiting" for this other creature. There might even be some sexual innuendo in this passage, as the snake gets satisfaction while the speaker has to wait around and "come[]" second. (On the surface, the poem isn't about sex at all, but its innuendo-laden [symbolism](#) and diction—plus its discussion of gender and psychology—seem to invite this kind of Freudian, psychological reading.)

Having vented his frustration for a moment, the speaker returns to observing the snake closely. He layers on detail after detail, with the help of [repetition](#) (particularly [anaphora](#) and [epistrophe](#)):

He lifted his head from his **drinking, as cattle do,**
And looked at me vaguely, **as drinking cattle do,**
And flickered his two-forked tongue from his lips, and
 mused a moment,
And stooped **and** drank a little more,

If all these long verses beginning with "And" sound a little biblical, that's no accident! The poem makes no direct biblical [allusions](#), but its style seems to echo the King James Bible in particular. And its subject matter (a snake and human beneath a tree) clearly recalls the Eden story from the Book of Genesis. In that story, of course, Adam and Eve unwisely follow the advice of a devilish serpent, who represents evil and temptation.

In Lawrence's poem, it's not immediately clear what, if anything, the snake represents. As it drinks from the trough and glances around "vaguely" (distractedly), it looks as harmless as domestic "cattle." It shoots out its "[f]orked tongue"—a feature symbolically associated with deceit—but "muse[s]" to itself rather than interacting with the speaker. For the moment, at least, it seems quiet and tame, not evil or dangerous. Far from a Satan-like menace to humans, it doesn't appear concerned with humans at all (except insofar as they provide water).

Still, the speaker observes the snake's "earth-brown, earth-golden" color and associates it with both earth and fire. He claims that the snake comes "from the burning bowels of the earth / On the day of Sicilian July, with Etna smoking." Mount

Etna is an active volcano in eastern Sicily, where the poem is set. In [juxtaposing](#) the snake with the "smok[e]" from this volcano, the poem suggests that both are products of "the burning bowels of the earth." Basically, the speaker is making the snake sound pretty hellish! From a human perspective, the creature seems to carry a malevolent aura, even if it isn't literally the devil.

LINES 22-26

*The voice of my education said to me
 He must be killed,
 For in Sicily the black, black snakes are innocent, the gold are venomous.
 And voices in me said, If you were a man
 You would take a stick and break him now, and finish him off.*

There's an important shift in lines 22-26, as the speaker contemplates taking some *action*. Until now, he's been effectively frozen, water pitcher in hand, watching the snake's every move. Now he hears an inner voice telling him to *do* something: "The voice of my education said to me / He must be killed." He feels a duty to get rid of this brownish-gold pest before it hurts someone—because "in Sicily the black, black snakes are innocent, the gold are venomous."

But the speaker feels this duty only on an abstract, intellectual level. "The voice of [his] education" tells him to kill the snake, but that doesn't mean his heart is in it. His frozen stance suggests indecision or ambivalence. Meanwhile, other internal "voices" are goading him, too—voices of shame and social expectation. "If you were a man," they taunt him, "You would take a stick and break [the snake] now, and finish him off."

Notice the ambiguity in these lines. Is the speaker a woman? A nonbinary person (to use a term that wasn't available to D. H. Lawrence in 1923)? Or a man worrying that he isn't manly enough? Because Lawrence was male, and because this poem is grounded in his real-life circumstances (he lived in Taormina, Sicily during this period), this guide refers to the speaker as male also. But the ambiguity seems to be part of the point. The speaker clearly feels challenged or threatened by the snake, and his very identity feels unstable as a result.

LINES 27-34

*But must I confess how I liked him,
 How glad I was he had come like a guest in quiet, to drink at my water-trough
 And depart peaceful, pacified, and thankless,
 Into the burning bowels of this earth?
 Was it cowardice, that I dared not kill him?
 Was it perversity, that I longed to talk to him?
 Was it humility, to feel so honoured?
 I felt so honoured.*

Lines 27-34 delve deeper into the speaker's inner conflict. The speaker begins asking himself [rhetorical questions](#), as if grilling

himself about his motives:

But must I confess how I liked him,
How glad I was he had come like a guest in quiet, to
drink at my water-trough
And depart peaceful, pacified, and thankless,
Into the burning bowels of this earth?

This first question is long and complex; it takes up a full [stanza](#). The speaker admits, without quite stating it outright, that he "liked" the dangerous snake. The snake doesn't actually threaten the speaker in any way; it's as "quiet" and "peaceful" as a good "guest." When it finishes drinking, it's "pacified" (satisfied) and goes on its way. In another moment of [anthropomorphism](#), the speaker calls the snake "thankless" or ungrateful for its drink of water—but, of course, it's only a snake, so it can't really express gratitude! It retreats back into the hellish "bowels of the earth," yet it seems more gentle than evil.

Though the speaker claims that he "liked" the snake, and that watching it made him "glad," it's clear his feelings aren't so simple. He's a little miffed by the snake, too, and feels a duty to get rid of it rather than indulging it.

Next, he asks three shorter and more pointed questions:

Was it cowardice, that I dared not kill him?
Was it perversity, that I longed to talk to him?
Was it humility, to feel so honoured?

These might be summarized as follows:

1. Was I cowardly for not stepping up and killing the snake?
2. Was I weird for wanting to communicate with it?
3. Did I feel honored by its presence because it humbled me, or for some other reason?

The speaker then turns this last question into a declarative statement: "I felt so honoured." Taken together, these three questions imply that the speaker admired the snake too much to kill it. Deep down, that is, he sympathized with the animal, wanted to understand it better, and wanted it to stick around. At the same time, he leaves open the possibility that he's just making excuses—that he's a coward pretending to be an animal lover. The poem keeps adding layer after layer of psychological complexity, refusing to present a definitive account of the speaker's motives.

LINES 35-40

*And yet those voices:
If you were not afraid, you would kill him.
And truly I was afraid, I was most afraid,
But even so, honoured still more*

*That he should seek my hospitality
From out the dark door of the secret earth.*

In lines 35-40, the poem adds more layers of complexity to its psychological portrait. There's almost a [stream-of-consciousness](#) effect here, as the speaker seems to think aloud and examine his own feelings on the fly:

*And yet those voices:
If you were not afraid, you would kill him.
And truly I was afraid, I was most afraid,
But even so, honoured still more
That he should seek my hospitality [...]*

His taunting inner voices tell him he's too scared to kill the snake. He admits that he was scared—very scared—but insists that he was even more "honoured" than he was fearful. He claims to be proud that the snake "should seek my hospitality": that is, grace his home with its presence while looking for a drink of water. Again, part of the snake's allure derives from its origins; to the speaker, it's like a mysterious, supernatural visitor emerging "From out the dark door of the secret earth."

At this point, the speaker seems almost as conflicted in the present (i.e., while telling the story) as he was while observing the snake. He [repeats](#) the word "afraid" three times in these lines, yet he also repeats "honoured" three times between line 33 and line 38. It's as if he's conducting an inner argument about his own motives. Clearly he was *both* afraid and happy to have the snake in his yard. But which feeling took precedence? The reader is forced to play judge—or psychologist.

LINES 41-49

*He drank enough
And lifted his head, dreamily, as one who has drunken,
And flickered his tongue like a forked night on the air, so
black,
Seeming to lick his lips,
And looked around like a god, unseeing, into the air,
And slowly turned his head,
And slowly, very slowly, as if thrice adream,
Proceeded to draw his slow length curving round
And climb again the broken bank of my wall-face.*

Lines 41-49 span another long descriptive [stanza](#). With a mix of fear and fascination, the speaker continues to watch the snake's every move. Once the snake has "enough" water, the speaker reports, it begins to move "slowly" away from the trough. In fact, the speaker repeats "slowly" three times (along with the word "slow") to drive home how leisurely and deliberate the snake's pace is. Meanwhile, the [repetition](#) of "And" or "And slowly" at the start of lines (an example of [anaphora](#) and [polysyndeton](#)) gives the language a stately, almost biblical quality:

And lifted his head, dreamily, as one who has
 drunken,
 And flickered his tongue like a forked night on the air,
 so black,
 Seeming to lick his lips,
 And looked around like a god, unseeing, into the air,
 And slowly turned his head,
 And slowly, very slowly, as if thrice adream,
 Proceeded to draw his slow length curving round [...]

Notice how well the quasi-biblical style fits the [simile](#) here: "[he] looked around like a god, unseeing." The snake is moving and behaving with the stately dignity of a deity; it's so aloof that it doesn't even seem to "see[]" the speaker or anything else around it. It "lifts [its] head" as "dreamily" as a drunk person ("one who has drunken"), "turn[s]" deliberately to and fro, and gradually "Proceed[s] to draw" away from the trough in a "curving" motion. So leisurely is its pace that it looks "thrice adream," or asleep three times over. Its rapidly "flicker[ing]" tongue, which seems "to lick [its] lips" in satisfaction, provides the only contrast with these slow movements. (And the contrast makes it all the more startling and creepy, especially because its tongue is as "black" as "night.")

As in previous passages, this snake description is full of [sibilance](#), which gives the language a snake-like hissing quality. Lines 47-48 are a perfect example: "And slowly, very slowly, as if thrice adream, / Proceeded to draw his slow length curving round." No matter how much the speaker claims to "like[]" the snake, this relentless sibilance makes it sound sinister!

Once the snake has left the trough, it "climb[s] again the broken bank" of the speaker's "wall-face." In other words, it slithers up the cracked earthen wall and prepares to return to its hole. It's trying to make a quiet exit—but the drama isn't over yet.

LINES 50-54

*And as he put his head into that dreadful hole,
 And as he slowly drew up, snake-easing his shoulders, and
 entered farther,
 A sort of horror, a sort of protest against his withdrawing
 into that horrid black hole,
 Deliberately going into the blackness, and slowly drawing
 himself after,
 Overcame me now his back was turned.*

The snake has almost left the yard without incident. But in lines 50-54, the speaker gets seriously creeped out at the last minute. Something about the way the snake slithers back into its "dreadful hole" makes him recoil in disgust. The poet tries to evoke this same disgust in the reader through lurid visual [imagery](#):

And as he slowly drew up, snake-easing his
 shoulders, and entered farther,

A sort of horror, a sort of protest against his
 withdrawing into that horrid black hole,
 Deliberately going into the blackness, and slowly
 drawing himself after,
 Overcame me now his back was turned.

In other words, the snake's slow, slithery, bendy exit—as well as the "blackness" it's exiting into—looks absolutely disgusting. The speaker's whole body seems to clench in "A sort of horror, a sort of protest." He's "Overc[o]me" with revulsion and fear, even though the snake's "back" is now "turned" (i.e., the speaker is no longer in any danger).

What's going on here? To some degree, of course, the creepiness of the imagery speaks for itself. But it might carry some disturbing [symbolism](#) as well. The snake's entrance into the hole might evoke the act of sexual penetration; the hole's "blackness" might also bring to mind death and the grave. And that *combination* of sex/death overtones is disturbing in its own right! More generally, the speaker seems disturbed by the stark reality of *nature* (which encompasses sex, death, and wild animals alike). That reality isn't always picturesque or poetic! But Lawrence's poem tries to capture it honestly, even as the speaker shudders in "protest."

LINES 55-62

*I looked round, I put down my pitcher,
 I picked up a clumsy log
 And threw it at the water-trough with a clatter.
 I think it did not hit him,
 But suddenly that part of him that was left behind convulsed
 in an undignified haste,
 Writhed like lightning, and was gone
 Into the black hole, the earth-lipped fissure in the wall-front,
 At which, in the intense still noon, I stared with fascination.*

After many [stanzas](#) of passive staring, the speaker finally takes action in lines 55-62. He decides to try to kill the snake after all—though belatedly and rather halfheartedly. For the first time, sound [imagery](#) enters the poem, and the effect is startling:

I looked round, I put down my pitcher,
 I picked up a clumsy log
 And threw it at the water-trough with a clatter.

If the log is "clumsy" and unwieldy, the sound is awkward and unpleasant: it shatters the breathless silence in which the speaker had been watching the snake. If the speaker is trying to prove his courage or manliness here, he has done a poor job. Recall that in lines 25-26, the voices in his head taunted, "If you were a man / You would take a stick and break him." The speaker's actual kill attempt is like a botched version of that scenario. He acts only when the snake's back is already turned

(a sign of cowardice). Rather than a simple and efficient "stick," he uses a cumbersome "log" (as if overcompensating for his insecurities by grabbing the biggest phallic [symbol](#) he can find).

And his throw is ineffectual. The log doesn't kill the snake; it may not even "hit" the snake. Startled, the snake "convulse[s]" its body and "Writhe[s]" its tail around "like lightning." For a moment, it shows an "undignified haste," in a sharp contrast with its normal, regal attitude. Then it slithers into the "black hole" that upsets the speaker (the dirt-rimmed hole in the wall, or "earth-lipped fissure in the wall-front"). Even after it's gone, the speaker continues "star[ing] with fascination," as if processing what has just happened. Silence resumes: the "noon" air is "intense" and "still" again.

The snake looks "undignified" for only a moment, but the speaker loses quite a bit of dignity here (or so he feels). The rest of the poem will dwell on his embarrassment and regret.

LINES 63-67

*And immediately I regretted it.
I thought how paltry, how vulgar, what a mean act!
I despised myself and the voices of my accursed human education.
And I thought of the albatross,
And I wished he would come back, my snake.*

In lines 63-67, the speaker "Immediately [...]" regret[s]" throwing the log at the snake. In fact, he beats himself up over it. This bitter regret may seem odd at first; after all, he hasn't actually hurt the snake, and no other humans have witnessed his awkward throw. Besides, for many people, shooing a pest from their yard would be an unremarkable event. If the speaker's made a mistake, it's only a tiny one, but to him, it feels [huge](#).

He calls his act "paltry," "vulgar," and "mean"—that is, petty, lowly, and nasty. He "despise[s]" himself for listening to "the voices of my accursed human education," rather than trusting his instinct to leave the snake alone. The voices here also seem to be voices of human *civilization*, urging the speaker to dominate nature and rid his home of any threats to human comfort. (The word "accursed" might also point back to the Eden story, in which listening to a wily snake and following their sexual instincts gets Adam and Eve cursed and expelled from paradise. Here, [ironically](#), it's the *rejection* of a snake—and, by extension, nature and the instinct—that seems to bring down a curse.)

The speaker then expresses his regret through a more specific [allusion](#):

*And I thought of the albatross,
And I wished he would come back, my snake.*

This is a reference to Samuel Taylor Coleridge's famous poem "[The Rime of the Ancient Mariner](#)" (1798), in which sailors fall

under a curse after one of them shoots an "albatross" (a large white seabird). The sailor who shot the bird has to wear the dead albatross "About [his] neck," as if carrying Christ's "cross." In Lawrence's poem, the speaker's allusion conveys his superstitious feeling that he's done something terribly wrong—offended nature or the gods by trying to kill the snake.

LINES 68-74

*For he seemed to me again like a king,
Like a king in exile, uncrowned in the underworld,
Now due to be crowned again.
And so, I missed my chance with one of the lords
Of life.
And I have something to expiate:
A pettiness.*

Lines 68-74 conclude the poem with a statement of shame and remorse. In the poem's final [simile](#), the speaker again elevates the snake to royal or divine status:

*For he seemed to me again like a king,
Like a king in exile, uncrowned in the underworld,
Now due to be crowned again.*

The speaker appears to be [alluding](#), here, to the ancient Greek god Hades or other mythological kings of the underworld. He imagines that the snake visited the upper world as an "exile" from its kingdom, then returned home (slithered back underground) because it was "due" to regain its crown. (In Greek myth, Hades rules over a kingdom of ghosts, so this allusion once again links the snake with death and helps explain the speaker's fear.)

Though the snake is deadly, the speaker ultimately sees it as "one of the lords / Of life": a phrase that implies something like *one of the forces of nature* or *one of the kings of the animal world*. By attacking the snake—disrespecting it and offending its dignity—the speaker feels he's "missed [his] chance" with a powerful entity. The language here is [figurative](#); the speaker isn't literally claiming the snake was divine or supernatural. Rather, he feels he's lost out on a deeper connection with this extraordinary creature. He regrets spoiling rather than appreciating their awe-inspiring encounter.

As a result, he feels he has "something to expiate," or an offense to atone for. (The word "expiate" has religious [connotations](#); it was originally associated with rites meant to purge sin or ward off evil.) His offense is just plain "pettiness"—not an actual sin according to most religious traditions, but a sin in *his* worldview. He may not have done any great harm, but his behavior was mean, lowly, and unworthy of the dignified snake. Now, after his sudden confrontation with nature, he feels all too human.



SYMBOLS



THE SNAKE

The snake in "Snake" [symbolizes](#) several things at once:

- First, it's a symbol of untamed nature intruding on the "educat[ed]" speaker's civilized, tame, "human" world.
- Second, it's a symbol of death and danger, since its venom could potentially kill a human being. (The speaker even compares the snake to a "king" of the "underworld," like the mythical Hades, king of the dead.)
- Third, because of its elongated shape and the way the speaker genders it as "he," it functions as a masculine or phallic symbol. In fact, the speaker seems threatened by the snake both as a human being in general and a "man" in particular. The snake cuts in front of him at the water-trough, as if undermining his claim to dominance. "If you were a man," his inner voice taunts, "You would take a stick and break him now, and finish him off." (For more on the gender complexities/ambiguities at play here, see the Speaker section of this guide.) Eventually, the speaker pits himself against the snake in a macho way, attempting to kill it (symbolically castrate it, perhaps) by throwing a log in its direction. Yet his attempt fails and becomes a gesture of futility and impotence.
- Finally, thanks in large part to the famous serpent in the Garden of Eden story, snakes often symbolize evil. This poem actually seems to *challenge* that symbolism. The snake is frightening to the speaker, but "peaceful" and unassuming as it goes about its business. And in the end, the speaker feels foolish and ashamed, not heroic, for trying to vanquish it.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-54
- Lines 58-62
- Lines 67-72



THE LOG

Like the snake, the "log" the speaker throws (lines 56-58) can be read as a phallic [symbol](#). Lawrence uses it for comic effect in the poem: the speaker's first idea is to kill the snake with a "stick" (line 26), so right away, throwing a log seems like overkill. The log is also "clumsy"—bulky and awkward—so it makes for a ridiculous weapon in the speaker's bid for macho dominance.

Finally, the log is ineffectual. Even if it hits the snake (and the speaker thinks "it did not"), it does no damage, and the snake escapes. If the log represents the speaker's manhood, then, it makes the speaker look awkward and impotent—and as if he might be overcompensating for his insecurities.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 56-58:** "I picked up a clumsy log / And threw it at the water-trough with a clatter. / I think it did not hit him,"



THE HOLE IN THE EARTH/CRACK IN THE WALL

The "fissure in the earth-wall," from which the snake crawls and to which it returns, doesn't clearly represent any one thing. Instead, through the speaker's descriptions, it's [symbolically](#) related to birth, death, and sex.

If the snake is a phallic or masculine symbol, the hole can be read as a yonic or feminine symbol. Notice that the wall is made of "earth," and the earth is often feminized in traditional myths—think Mother Earth, Gaia, and so on. The snake exiting and entering the hole, a.k.a. "the dark door of the secret earth," might evoke birth on the one hand and sexual penetration on the other. (It helps to know that Lawrence's writing, which is sexually frank in general, often made use of sexual symbolism—the kind that's still called "Freudian" in honor of the psychoanalyst Sigmund Freud.)

And yet, "the dark door of the secret earth" might bring to mind *death* rather than birth or female sexuality. After all, a *grave* is a kind of door into the earth. And the speaker later imagines the crack in the wall as a gateway to the "underworld," or the mythical land of the dead. So birth, death, and sex all seem to combine in this one image, which the speaker fixates on in "horror" (lines 50-53).

His recoiling from this "dreadful hole" might convey sexual disgust—or a more general disgust with *nature* and the way nature works. That is, he might feel horrified (however subconsciously) at the inextricable link between sex and birth, or between birth and death. As he lashes out in "protest" against the snake's "withdrawing into that horrid black hole," he looks like a sheltered human being struggling to come to grips with nature's stark realities.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Line 7:** "He reached down from a fissure in the earth-wall in the gloom"
- **Line 40:** "From out the dark door of the secret earth."
- **Lines 50-53:** "And as he put his head into that dreadful hole, / And as he slowly drew up, snake-easing his

shoulders, and entered farther, / A sort of horror, a sort of protest against his withdrawing into that horrid black hole, / Deliberately going into the blackness,"

- **Line 61:** "Into the black hole, the earth-lipped fissure in the wall-front,"



POETIC DEVICES

ANTHROPOMORPHISM

At various moments in the poem, the speaker [anthropomorphizes](#) the snake. That is, the speaker attributes human qualities, motives, and behaviors to the snake, even though it's a non-human animal. This pattern starts to develop around line 27, as the speaker admits to "lik[ing]" the snake and starts to portray "him" in sympathetic, relatable terms.

The speaker compares the snake to a "guest" (line 28) seeking out his "hospitality" (line 39)—something only a human being could *literally* do. He also describes the snake's attitude, after drinking from the "water-trough," as "peaceful, pacified, and thankful." Again, there's a touch of human characterization here. Only a person could have literally "thank[ed]" the speaker for his hospitality, yet the speaker imagines the snake as a quiet, unobtrusive, but somewhat aloof or ungrateful guest. Continuing this fantasy in line 32, the speaker even finds himself "long[ing] to talk to" the snake—an obviously impossible wish.

Later, the speaker projects not only human but *royal* qualities onto the snake. He notes that the snake briefly looks "undignified" as it escapes—but this brief lapse only highlights how dignified it looks the rest of the time. (Of course, *dignity* is a fundamentally human concept.) The snake even reminds the speaker of "a king in exile," one who is returning home "to be crowned again."

In all these cases, the anthropomorphism highlights the strange mix of sympathy and antipathy the speaker feels toward the snake. Their encounter seems to bridge the human and natural worlds in an uncanny way. At the same time, the device suggests that the speaker is projecting his own fears and insecurities onto the snake. For example, the snake seems so regal and powerful in part because the speaker—to whom the snake's venom could be lethal—feels so *vulnerable*. Likewise, that adjective "thankless" hints at some insecurity on the speaker's part. There's no way the snake could actually thank him, so the speaker's feeling of being snubbed might reflect the inversion of the usual power dynamic between people and animals. The animal has the upper hand here, so to speak, so the speaker feels both impressed and slightly miffed.

Where Anthropomorphism appears in the poem:

- **Lines 27-30:** "But must I confess how I liked him, / How glad I was he had come like a guest in quiet, to drink at my water-trough / And depart peaceful, pacified, and thankful, / Into the burning bowels of this earth?"
- **Line 32:** "Was it perversity, that I longed to talk to him?"
- **Lines 38-40:** "honoured still more / That he should seek my hospitality / From out the dark door of the secret earth."
- **Line 59:** "But suddenly that part of him that was left behind convulsed in an undignified haste,"
- **Lines 68-70:** "For he seemed to me again like a king, / Like a king in exile, uncrowned in the underworld, / Now due to be crowned again."

ALLUSION

The poem contains one explicit [allusion](#), in lines 66-67:

And I thought of the albatross,
And I wished he would come back, my snake.

The poet/speaker is alluding to one of the most famous poems in the English language, Samuel Taylor Coleridge's "[The Rime of the Ancient Mariner](#)." In this poem, a mariner shoots an albatross—a large white seabird—that has helped guide his crew. As a result, the crew becomes cursed with misfortune, and the mariner is forced to wear the dead albatross around his neck until the curse lifts:

Ah! well a-day! what evil looks
Had I from old and young!
Instead of the cross, the Albatross
About my neck was hung.

The speaker's allusion, therefore, conveys a fear that he's offended nature, or perhaps God/the gods, by attempting to kill the snake. Superstitiously, he worries that his "mean act" will bring him bad luck, and he "wishes" the snake "would come back" so that he might have a chance to behave differently.

The speaker also compares the snake to "a king in exile" from "the underworld," a [simile](#) that invokes various underworld kings from ancient mythology. In Western culture, the most famous of these kings is Hades, from Greek myth (along with his counterpart, Pluto, from Roman myth). Hades rules over the kingdom of the dead, so the comparison here again seems to link the snake with death. (Remember, the speaker is "afraid" of the snake's deadly venom.) The speaker imagines that this snake-king has emerged into daylight because he's in brief "exile" from his underworld kingdom; he's vulnerable up here in the world of the living, but he's about to return and resume his powers. On the literal level, this myth-flavored fantasy suggests that the snake is escaping down his hole, where the speaker can no longer harm him.

Finally, because the poem involves a serpent, a large tree (see line 4), and a sense of shame, it's most likely playing on the Garden of Eden myth, even if it never makes any direct biblical allusions. Unlike Adam and Eve in the Book of Genesis, who unwisely listen to the evil serpent (and eat from the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil), the speaker here shames himself by *rejecting* and trying to get rid of a snake. In that sense, the poem might be read as a critique of Christianity—perhaps even a suggestion that true shame lies in rejecting the complex realities of nature. (Lawrence was a religious pluralist who believed there were many paths to God, and wrote that his relationship to the Bible was often one of "dislike, repulsion, and even resentment." He was given a Christian religious education—"brought up on the Bible," as he put it—so his complaint about "my accursed human education" in line 65 might align with the poem's reworking of Christian myth.)

Where Allusion appears in the poem:

- **Lines 66-67:** "And I thought of the albatross, / And I wished he would come back, my snake."
- **Lines 68-70:** "For he seemed to me again like a king, / Like a king in exile, uncrowned in the underworld, / Now due to be crowned again."

REPETITION

The poem uses various kinds of [repetition](#) for pacing, emphasis, and dramatic effect.

Some repetitions fall in quick or immediate succession, as with the [epizeuxis](#) in line 2: "On a **hot, hot** day, and I in pyjamas for the heat." The immediate repetition of "hot"—plus the variation "heat" later in the line—strongly emphasizes how scorching a day this is. In that way, it helps establish the [setting](#) (Sicily, July, noon). The poem also contains several instances of [diacope](#), as in line 6:

And **must wait, must** stand and **wait**, for there he was
at the trough before me.

Here, the repetition affects pacing: it slows down the line and extends the image, so that the reader has to "wait" a bit along with the speaker. (In fact, quite a bit of the poem focuses on the speaker's waiting and on the snake's leisurely movements: the snake is described five times as moving "slowly," including three times in lines 46-47.)

The poem also makes heavy use of [anaphora](#), particularly anaphora involving the word "And." Between lines 42-51, for example, eight out of 10 lines start with "And." (No fewer than 26 lines start with "And" across the poem as a whole.) This effect offsets the poem's casual [tone](#) a bit: it sounds incantatory, almost scriptural, and echoes the many "And [...]" verses of the King James Bible in particular. In that way, it

imparts a bit of traditional poetic flavor to this experimental, prose-like, [free verse](#) piece.

Anaphora and [parallelism](#) also help the poem build emotional force, as in the [rhetorical questions](#) of lines 31-33:

Was it cowardice, **that** I dared not kill **him**?
Was it perversity, **that** I longed to talk to **him**?
Was it humility, to feel so honoured?

This pileup of parallel questions creates a layered emotional complexity, while giving the impression that the speaker is interrogating himself. In his bitter "regret[]" (see line 63), he really wants to understand why he behaved as he did—and he signals that these kinds of psychological questions are what readers should be asking also.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 2:** "hot, hot"
- **Line 6:** "must wait,," "must," "wait,"
- **Line 7:** "down"
- **Line 8:** "And," "slackness," "down," "stone"
- **Line 9:** "And," "stone"
- **Line 10:** "And"
- **Line 11:** "his straight"
- **Line 12:** "his straight," "slack"
- **Line 15:** "waiting"
- **Line 16:** "drinking," "as cattle do,"
- **Line 17:** "And," "as drinking cattle do,"
- **Line 18:** "And," "flickered his two-forked tongue," "and"
- **Line 19:** "And"
- **Line 20:** "earth," "earth," "the burning bowels of," "earth"
- **Line 22:** "The voice," "of my education"
- **Line 24:** "black, black"
- **Line 25:** "voices," "If you were"
- **Line 26:** "You would"
- **Line 27:** "how"
- **Line 28:** "How"
- **Line 30:** "the burning bowels of," "earth"
- **Line 31:** "Was it," "that I," "him?"
- **Line 32:** "Was it," "that I," "him?"
- **Line 33:** "Was it," "so honoured"
- **Line 34:** "so honoured"
- **Line 35:** "voices"
- **Line 36:** "If you were," "you would"
- **Line 37:** "I was afraid,," "I was," "afraid,"
- **Line 38:** "honoured"
- **Line 40:** "earth"
- **Line 42:** "And," "his head,"
- **Line 43:** "And," "flickered his tongue like a forked"
- **Line 45:** "And"
- **Line 46:** "And slowly," "his head,"
- **Line 47:** "And slowly," "slowly"

- **Line 49:** "And"
- **Line 50:** "And as he," "into that," "hole"
- **Line 51:** "And as he," "slowly"
- **Line 52:** "A sort of," "a sort of," "into that," "black," "hole"
- **Line 53:** "blackness," "slowly"
- **Line 55:** "I," "I"
- **Line 56:** "I"
- **Line 61:** "black hole"
- **Line 64:** "I," "how," "how"
- **Line 65:** "I," "the voices of my," "education"
- **Line 66:** "And I"
- **Line 67:** "And I"
- **Line 68:** "again," "like a king"
- **Line 69:** "Like a king"
- **Line 70:** "again"
- **Line 71:** "And"
- **Line 73:** "And"

IMAGERY

The poem's rich, detailed [imagery](#) showcases D. H. Lawrence's gift for novelistic description. (He was and is more famous as a fiction writer than a poet!)

Much of the imagery, of course, is visual, and related to the snake itself. In meticulous detail, the speaker describes the snake's "earth-brown, earth-golden" body; emphasizes six times that the snake is moving "slowly" (at least until its moment of "undignified haste"); zooms in on the creature's "straight gums" and "black tongue"; and so on. This extreme precision conveys how keenly the speaker is observing the snake, with a mix of fear, awe, resentment, disgust, and "fascination."

There's plenty of visual scene-setting, too, as the speaker picks out the surrounding details of the yard—including the "trough" with its "stone bottom" and "small clearness" of water, the earthen "wall" with its "earth-lipped fissure," and the "great dark carob tree" beneath which all the action takes place. In the case of the tree, the visual description is linked to smell imagery: the speaker describes the tree's "deep, strange-scented shade," leaving the precise odor to the imagination (for readers unfamiliar with carob trees, at least).

The poem also features a great deal of tactile (touch) imagery related to the heat. From line 2 onward ("On a **hot, hot** day, and I in pyjamas for the **heat**"), the speaker emphasizes the scorching temperature of this July day in Sicily. Even the shade of the tree seems to provide little relief—and the poem never shows the speaker getting his drink of water. The heat imagery intensifies the poem's emotional/psychological atmosphere; you can almost feel the speaker sweating as he watches the dangerous snake and decides what to do.

For most of the poem, there's very little sound imagery; instead, the speaker notes how "Silent[]" everything is (line 13). Then, in

line 57, the "clatter" of the log against the "water-trough" shatters the silence. This sudden *intrusion* of sound helps suggest that the speaker has spoiled the moment—a moment of intense fear, yes, but also wonder. Right afterward, the stillness of "the intense still noon" resumes (62), and the speaker is left to contemplate his act in silence.

Where Imagery appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-13
- Lines 14-15
- Lines 16-21
- Line 24
- Lines 28-30
- Line 40
- Lines 41-62

RHETORICAL QUESTION

Close to the midway point of the poem, the speaker asks a series of [rhetorical questions](#) about the snake. The first of these is a snaking, complex sentence that takes up a full [stanza](#). The other three are simpler and punchier:

But must I confess how I liked him,
How glad I was he had come like a guest in quiet, to
drink at my water-trough
And depart peaceful, pacified, and thankless,
Into the burning bowels of this earth?
Was it cowardice, that I dared not kill him?
Was it perversity, that I longed to talk to him?
Was it humility, to feel so honoured?

The first question asks, in effect, "Do I *have* to admit how much I enjoyed having the snake in my yard?" Over the course of the four-line sentence, the speaker concedes that the snake is "quiet" (like a respectful "guest") and "peaceful" (not aggressive or dangerous). Once the snake finishes its drink, it's "pacified" (satisfied or soothed). And though it doesn't "thank[]" the speaker in any way—how can it?—it "depart[s]" without a fuss, back into the hellish "bowels of the earth." It might seem like a creature from the underworld, that is, but it's remarkably low-key, and the speaker is "glad" to watch it for a while. The rhetorical question *conveys* all this without declaratively *stating* it, because the speaker worries that he shouldn't be enjoying the snake so much—he should be killing it instead.

The next three questions press this point. The speaker wonders if he's a "coward[]" because he "dared not kill" the pest. He wonders if he's "pervers[e]"—eccentric or somehow unnatural—for wanting to "talk to" the snake instead of killing it. (Of course, this is an impossible desire.) Finally, he confesses that he felt "honoured" to be in the snake's presence, but wonders if this feeling really stemmed from "humility." (Perhaps his seeming humility toward nature was just an excuse for

cowardice.)

Taken together, these rhetorical questions express a deep anxiety. They imply that the speaker *did* have all these contradictory feelings: gladness, fear, humility, and a strange desire to communicate with the snake. But the speaker seems to be wondering which feeling took precedence and caused him to behave as he did.

Where Rhetorical Question appears in the poem:

- **Lines 27-30:** "But must I confess how I liked him, / How glad I was he had come like a guest in quiet, to drink at my water-trough / And depart peaceful, pacified, and thankless, / Into the burning bowels of this earth?"
- **Lines 31-33:** "Was it cowardice, that I dared not kill him? / Was it perversity, that I longed to talk to him? / Was it humility, to feel so honoured?"



VOCABULARY

Pyjamas (Line 2) - Night-clothes, often of a light and loose kind. Also spelled *pajamas*.

Carob tree (Line 4) - An evergreen tree with a broad crown and fruit pods, native to the Mediterranean and Middle Eastern regions.

Fissure (Line 7, Line 61) - A crack or opening.

Second-comer (Line 15) - The second to arrive somewhere. It's implied that, as a "second-comer," the speaker is also a *latecomer* (the snake has beat him to the trough).

Bowels (Line 20, Line 30) - The depths, inner parts, or internal regions.

Etna (Line 21) - Mount Etna, a famous active volcano on the eastern coast of Sicily.

Perversity (Line 32) - Here meaning eccentricity or willful contrarianism.

Thrice (Line 47) - Triply; three times over.

Adream (Line 47) - Dreaming or daydreaming. "Thrice adream" [hyperbolically](#) suggests that the snake is moving as slowly as if it's fallen asleep three times over.

Convulsed (Line 59) - Twitched or trembled violently.

Paltry (Line 64) - Petty.

Accursed (Line 65) - Terrible; regrettable. (Here used as a milder version of a word like "damned.")

The albatross (Line 66) - An albatross is a type of large seabird. Lawrence is [alluding](#) to Samuel Taylor Coleridge's famous poem "[The Rime of the Ancient Mariner](#)" (1798), in which an albatross brings bad luck to the sailors who kill it. (See the Allusion entry in the Devices section of this guide.)

Lords of life (Lines 71-72) - An ambiguous phrase, suggesting something like "the kings of Nature" or "the most vibrant creatures on earth."

Expiate (Line 73) - Atone for.



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"Snake" consists of 19 stanzas of [free verse](#). Both its lines and its [stanzas](#) vary considerably in length: the lines range from two to 23 syllables, while the stanzas range from two to nine lines. Because it's free verse, the poem contains no [rhyme scheme](#) and never settles into a regular [meter](#); instead, its language is loose, chatty, and prose-like.

In many ways, the poem's original form reflects the early-20th-century modernist period during which Lawrence wrote it. Modernist poets adopted experimental techniques, particularly free verse, in order to depict a world that had changed drastically since the 1800s—due to rapidly evolving technology, cataclysmic warfare, accelerating urbanization, and other watershed events. (Freudian psychoanalysis shook up the culture of this time, too, and it seems to be a particular influence on this poem. See the Context section of this guide for more.)

The prosy language here might also reflect Lawrence's training in his primary genre: fiction. Lawrence remains best known as a novelist, author of [Sons and Lovers](#) (1913), [The Rainbow](#) (1915), [Women in Love](#) (1920), [Lady Chatterley's Lover](#) (1928), and other classics. "Snake" is a narrative poem of sorts, and its speaker sounds more like the narrator of a prose anecdote than the voice of a traditional lyric poem.

METER

As a [free verse](#) poem, "Snake" has no consistent [meter](#). In fact, it seems to go out of its way to avoid falling into one. Its lines vary radically in length, from two syllables (line 72) to 23 syllables (line 52), and it never comes close to maintaining a regular rhythm.

Lawrence is participating, here, in the wave of literary/artistic experimentation now known as modernism, during which many poets threw conventional rules of meter, rhyme, etc. out the window. (The first wave of modernism reached its height in the 1920s, and "Snake" was published in 1923.) And the highly irregular line lengths serve another purpose in this particular poem: they make the language seem to twist, turn, and *snake* down the page. The effect is unpredictable, sometimes unsettling or startling, but has its own strange kind of beauty—much like the snake at the speaker's trough.

RHYME SCHEME

"Snake" is written in [free verse](#), so it has no [rhyme scheme](#) (and

no real [end rhyme](#) of any kind). There are a few moments of [repetition](#) at the ends of lines (e.g., "cattle do" in lines 16-17), and an incidental rhyme or two (e.g., "fascination" and "education" in lines 62 and 65), but for the most part, the poem reads more like prose than structured verse.

Lawrence was a novelist and short story writer as well as a poet—in fact, it's his fiction that made him famous. Here, it's as if he's blending genres, aiming for something more like prose poetry, or an anecdote with [line breaks](#), than a traditional lyric.



SETTING

The [setting](#) of the poem is Taormina, a town on the eastern coast of the Italian island of Sicily. Lawrence actually added the word "*Taormina*" as a kind of endnote to "Snake," and it appears in many [printed editions](#) of the poem.

Like other Mediterranean islands, Sicily tends to get very hot and dry in the summertime. Lawrence's poem is set "On a hot, hot day" in the middle of "July," during which Sicily's most famous peak, the volcanic Mount "Etna," is "smoking" from its crater. It's so hot that the speaker is still wearing "pyjamas" at noon in an effort to stay cool.

More immediately, the setting is some kind of yard on the speaker's property. In this yard stands a giant "carob tree" shading a cracked "earth-wall" and a "water-trough." The wall contains a "hole" that leads down into "the burning bowels of the earth"; the snake slithers out of this hole at the start of this poem and slithers back in at the end. (The speaker imagines the hole as the entrance to a mythical "underworld," in which the snake reigns as "king.")

"Snake" is a psychologically complex poem, and in various ways, its setting mirrors (or contributes to) its emotional atmosphere. For example, the heat of the "intense still noon" both reflects and ratchets up the poem's psychological intensity, as the speaker sweats and frets over what might otherwise be a mundane incident. Likewise, the emergence of the snake from the earth (and smoke from the crater of Etna) hints at tensions brewing beneath the surface of the speaker's psyche. In a way, it's as if the snake has crawled straight out of the speaker's unconscious mind, forcing him to confront his fears and insecurities.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

David Herbert Lawrence (1885-1930) was an English novelist, short story writer, and poet. Highly regarded for such groundbreaking works as *Sons and Lovers* and *The Rainbow*, he became best known for his controversial novel [Lady Chatterley's Lover](#) (1928), which faced an obscenity trial for its explicit language and depictions of sex. The trial, ironically, boosted the book's popularity, and it went on to sell millions of copies. Lawrence also wrote hundreds of poems, with "Snake" featuring in his celebrated 1923 collection *Birds, Beasts and Flowers*. As its title suggests, this collection is nature-themed—divided into sections such as "Fruits," "Trees," and "Birds" ("Snake" appears in the "Reptiles" section, of course).

Lawrence was included in the first *Georgian Poetry* anthology, published in 1912 and named for the reign of King George V. But critics more often group Lawrence in with modernism: an



SPEAKER

The speaker of the poem seems to be a stand-in for D. H. Lawrence himself. The speaker is living or staying in "Sicily," with a view of Mount "Etna" (a volcano on the east coast of Sicily)—just as Lawrence himself was while writing the poem. In the early 1920s, he and his wife Frieda lived briefly in the Sicilian town of Taormina, as part of a long period of global travel he called his "savage pilgrimage." (Lawrence also added the endnote "*Taormina*" to "Snake," which helps ground the poem in his life circumstances at the time.)

Though the poem is called "Snake," it's really a psychological portrait of the speaker, who describes his *reactions* to the snake in great detail. He wavers between admiring and attacking the snake—between "the voices of my accursed human education," which tell him to kill the dangerous pest, and a more generous spirit that feels "honoured" by the snake's visit. He worries about his own "cowardice" for wanting to leave the snake alone, and his "perversity" (that is, eccentricity) for wanting to communicate with the snake somehow ("talk to him"). He feels compelled to prove his humanity *and* masculinity by conquering the snake—yet he feels a secret sympathy with the creature ("I liked him"). Ultimately, he bitterly regrets his choice to attack the snake; he kicks himself for his "paltry," "vulgar," "mean act."

The speaker's name and occupation are never stated, but his gender seems clear. His inner voices challenge him to act manlier, to fulfill the gender expectations of manhood: "If you were a man / You would take a stick and break him now, and finish him off." But wait: couldn't this statement be literal as well? Couldn't the speaker be a woman, challenging herself to act as a man traditionally would in this situation?

There is, in fact, some gender ambiguity here—and Lawrence's work was known for exploring the ambiguities and complexities of sex and gender. Because Lawrence was male and tied this poem to his personal circumstances, this guide refers to the speaker as "he"/"him" throughout—but with the caveat that the question isn't totally decided. Part of the point here is that the speaker seems unsure about his "man[hood]," or about how a "man" ought to act in this scenario.

early 20th-century movement that championed new, experimental artistic forms. Modernist poets rejected the rigid structures of the past, often turning instead to [free verse](#) in their writing. "Snake" is a representative and well-known example of Lawrence's free verse from this period.

Modernists also introduced the narrative technique called [stream of consciousness](#), which attempts to capture not only a speaker's thoughts but the actual experience of *thinking*. Though not quite a stream-of-consciousness poem, "Snake" is influenced by this technique, as readers may feel they're following the speaker's conflicted thoughts and memories in real time.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The early 20th century was a time of rapid and widespread change. The Victorian era (which coincided with the reign of Queen Victoria from 1837 to 1901) had been an age of strict morality and pronounced social inequality. Modernism arose at the tail end of this era, as writers responded to an increasingly fast-paced and unpredictable world with inventive forms that shattered the rigid conventions of the past.

Lawrence also had a deep interest in the burgeoning field of psychoanalysis, including the disconnect between people's outer appearances and their inner realities. These interests show through in "Snake," which turns an outwardly mundane anecdote—man throws log at snake—into a psychologically complex portrait of a human being's response to a dangerous animal. Arguably, the poem (with its phallic snake and log, yonic hole in the wall, etc.) draws on the kind of sexual [symbolism](#) now called "Freudian," after the psychoanalytic theories of [Sigmund Freud](#) (1856-1939). That is, it can be read as a disguised portrait of male sexual insecurity (see, e.g., the interior "voices" in lines 25-26: "If you were a man / You would take a stick and break him now"). Though no longer regarded as strictly scientific, Freud's writings about sex, neurosis, the unconscious mind, and other subjects had a seismic influence on the literature and thought of the early 20th century.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [The Poem Aloud](#) — Listen to a reading of "Snake." (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VsdBgzznb_g)
- [More About Lawrence](#) — A summary of D. H. Lawrence's life and career at Encyclopedia Britannica. (<https://www.britannica.com/biography/D-H-Lawrence>)
- [The Poet's Life and Work](#) — A biography of Lawrence at the Poetry Foundation. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/d-h-lawrence>)
- [The Poem in Context](#) — Read the poem as it appeared in the original (1923) edition of *Birds, Beasts and Flowers*. (<https://archive.org/details/birdsbeastsflowe00lawruoft/page/112/mode/2up>)
- [The Snake?](#) — Pictures of the asp, or asp viper, a likely candidate for the type of snake described in Lawrence's poem. (https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/Vipera_aspis)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER D. H. LAWRENCE POEMS

- [Piano](#)



HOW TO CITE

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